What's Actually Going On With Dad? A Short Guide to Seeing the Whole Situation

The four parts of a clear picture: what happened, a typical day, who does what, and the decision in front of you.

“How's Dad doing?” is a simple question, and this week the honest answer is a dozen loose pieces: a text from your sister, something a nurse said on the phone, what you saw for yourself on Sunday.

This guide explains what a clear picture of a care situation is made of, so each piece has somewhere to go. It explains. It doesn't assess Dad, and it doesn't say what your family should decide.

Start with the immediate decision

A week like this one often comes with a decision attached. Someone has said that something needs to be settled, sometimes with a date. So the first part of the picture is what set all this in motion, which decision comes next, and who needs to understand the situation today.

If Dad is in the hospital, the staff plan with the family for what happens after he leaves. Medicare's discharge checklist calls the patient and the caregiver important members of the planning team, and its first item is to write down the names and phone numbers of people to call with questions. [1]

The person you deal with there could be a discharge planning manager, a social worker, a nurse or another hospital representative, the Family Caregiver Alliance says. Whoever it is, their name belongs on your page. [2]

- Write the decision as one sentence, with who raised it and any date they gave.
- If you've heard about several decisions, list them all and ask the person who raised them which comes first.

Describe the situation

Broad labels hide most of what matters. “He's managing okay” and “he needs someone there” can both be said about the same man in the same week. One ordinary day, written out, says more: who is there in the morning, through the day, in the evening and overnight, and what each of them does.

It helps to know the kinds of help people mean. MedlinePlus, from the National Library of Medicine, lists what caregivers commonly do: helping with daily tasks like bathing, eating or taking medicine, doing housework and cooking, running errands, driving the person to appointments, providing company and emotional support, and arranging activities and medical care. [3]

As you write, keep two things apart: how things are arranged right now, and what someone has proposed should change. Note what changed and when, too. When several things happen in a few days, the order is the first thing to get lost.

- Describe an ordinary day this week, not the day it happened.
- Beside each proposed change, write who proposed it.

Map the people and the work

Start with a full list of the people, not only the relatives. When a family meets about care, the Family Caregiver Alliance says to include everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may include a family friend, a neighbor or a paid caregiver. The same people belong on your list. [4]

Then set what each person actually does beside what everyone assumes they do. The Alliance notes that families often don't think through who becomes the primary caregiver and what supporting roles the others will play, and that siblings may assume the one who is helping has everything covered. [5]

One more name matters: whoever coordinates the information. AARP's planning guide for families calls this a point person, someone who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. [6]

- Beside each task, write who does it and whether you've confirmed that with them.
- A task with no name beside it is a question to ask. It isn't a verdict on anyone, or on Dad's care.

Build the starting summary

The last part is putting it on one page. The roadmap's method is to sort what you have into three kinds: confirmed facts, what family members have observed, and questions nobody has answered yet.

Expect the accounts to differ. Parents often tell their children different things about how they're doing, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, which is a good reason to pool your information. Our own advice goes one step further: where two people remember it differently, write both versions and who gave each. [5]

Where you don't know something, write “not yet known.” A gap you've marked tells the next reader what to ask about. A guess reads like a fact.

Keeping it together matters as much as writing it. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention gives the same reason for a written care plan, which is a different document from this one: it keeps important caregiving information in one place. [7]

What this means for your family

- “What's going on with Dad?” becomes four short answers: what happened, what a typical day looks like, who does what, and what has to be decided next.
- Your part is to describe, and to mark what's unknown. It isn't to conclude.
- Disagreement goes on the page as it is. Nobody has to win before the page is useful.
- What the picture means for Dad's care is a question for the professionals who assess him: his doctor, his nurse, a social worker or your care consultant.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't explain any medical condition, say whether Dad has the help he needs, or tell your family what to decide. The lists and the remarks about families come from the sources below. Sorting notes into facts, observations and open questions is the Family Care Roadmap's own method.

Ready for the next step?

You know what a clear picture of Dad's situation is made of. The care interview builds it with you: it asks about his living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life in turn, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Your discharge planning checklist
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers

3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
6. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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